Week 23

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 6 · LESSON 3

Prophecy

BIG IDEA

Prophecy is trickier than history, because a fulfillment can be dismissed as coincidence or as staged. As students study Isaiah 52 and 53, expect hard questions, and meet them honestly instead of brushing them off.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Students can see the Bible as accurate history, but prophecy is trickier: a fulfillment can be waved off as coincidence or as manufactured to look fulfilled.
2. Students explore Isaiah 52 and 53 in their introduction activity, alongside the misconception, the illumination and the questions.
3. This may be the week students fire hard questions, especially at small group leaders. Write them down, research, and take an extra week to answer if needed.
4. Don't pretend to have every answer or brush a question off; students drawing closer can still fall away if their questions are dismissed.
5. Address the misconception directly: it seems impossible for one man to fulfill hundreds of prophecies, and Jesus fulfilled them in ways many didn't expect.
6. Many expected a political, military ruler to restore Israel; Jesus established a spiritual kingdom. That worldview shift was hard then and may be hard for students now.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO

Isaiah 52-53

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. How do I usually react when a student asks something I can't answer?
2. Have I built enough trust that students feel safe bringing me hard questions?
3. Where do my own expectations of Jesus differ from the kingdom He actually brought?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What makes a fulfilled prophecy convincing to you, and what makes it easy to dismiss?
2. What stands out to you in Isaiah 52 and 53, and how does it connect to Jesus?
3. Why do you think many people missed Jesus when He came as a different kind of Messiah?
4. What questions about prophecy would you like us to research together?
5. What expectations of God might you need to let go of to see who Jesus really is?

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WEEK 23 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Prophecy is tricky

0:06 All right — prophecy. Now think of it this way. If the Bible is both accurate and trustworthy, and we can know it to be true, and we can also know it to be historical, what then does that say about prophecy? Prophecy is tricky. It's almost as if we can believe that the Bible is accurate history. We can show that; it's concrete, and it lines up with some other things.

0:40 We can show that the Bible is completely accurate across all of history, and that it is 95% the same exact thing that Jesus actually said, or whatever. Prophecy is trickier, because prophecy can be something that you might just discount: "Well, that just sort of was happenstance," or "that was just coincidence, and it just happened that way." Or maybe it was manufactured to look like it was a fulfillment of prophecy.

Walking through this week

1:13 So here's the deal with this week. As you go through it piece by piece, as you walk students through the misconceptions and the illuminations, as you walk your students through and help guide them through their introduction activity and their exploration of Isaiah chapters 52 and 53, as you look at the questions and start to piece this whole week together, I want you to keep one thing in mind this week — and that's it.

When the questions come

1:45 This week could be a difficult week. This could be the week — one of those weeks when students start firing all kinds of questions at you, especially your small group leaders. So here's what we're going to do. We're going to write the questions down, and we're going to dig in and do some research. And I want you to come back, if you have to, and even take an additional week to answer those questions.

2:17 Don't pretend like you have all the answers. Now, you might have a bunch of the answers, and that's awesome. But if you don't, don't pretend, and don't brush it off, because we're sort of at that moment now where you probably have students who — especially if they started out very skeptical — are hopefully walking closer and closer and closer. But the closer you get, the easier it is to just fall off the edge.

2:44 Because if we discount a question, the train may just come off the rails, and it's maybe over. I don't know. So you want to approach these kinds of things very carefully. You've spent so much time and energy developing authentic and organic community, and trust with these students, and openness and honesty, and being able to ask the difficult questions. Now is one of those times when the difficult questions are going to start to come. When it comes to prophecy, there just may be those kinds of things.

3:15 I can't predict what kind of questions your students may ask, but from my experience, this is always one of those areas that just pops up. So if you don't know the answers, or your small group leaders don't know the answers, write them down, gather together, get some answers, bring your students back together, and give them the answers that they're seeking.

The misconception this week

3:39 So for this week, don't be afraid to directly address the misconception. Here's how we've worded it: it seems to be entirely impossible for one man to fulfill hundreds of prophecies, not to mention that the way Jesus fulfilled Messianic prophecy was very much contrary to popular Jewish theology. Jewish leaders were looking for the coming Messiah to be a political, military and spiritual ruler who would dethrone foreign rule and reestablish Israel as a world superpower. Instead, Jesus unexpectedly established his spiritual kingdom. It's a worldview shift that has prevented many from accepting Him as Savior.

4:26 Keep that in mind. This is a complete worldview shift for many. It was that way for Jews in the first century, and it's that way probably for many of your students as well. Don't be afraid to hit the bell.